Land at South Marston, Swindon
Additional Heritage Information
November 2016

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Report
Built Heritage – Appendix 8f

Site
Land at South Marston

Planning Authority
Swindon Borough Council

Site Centred At
SU 19936 87615

Prepared and Approved By
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Report Status
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1.0 Introduction and scope of document

1.1 This document has been produced following a meeting with Swindon Borough Council's (SBC) Conservation Officer and discussions with planning officers of the Council, during which additional information was requested to inform a planning application for development on land at South Marston, Swindon. This land is centred at NGR SU 19936 87615 and is hereafter referred to as the study site.

1.2 An ES Chapter has previously been produced (ES Chapter10: Historic Environment of the Environmental Statement for the Outline Planning Application for Land at South Marston and Rowborough, Swindon New Eastern Villages) as well as a Built Heritage Report produced in 2014 (CgMs 2014).

1.3 The SBC Conservation Officer and planning officer have requested further information on the following matters:

- Additional assessment of the potential effects to the significance of the grade I listed Church of St Mary Magdalene, situated approximately 300m to the north of the study site; specifically in relation to effects to the experience of the church tower from the surrounding area.

- Consideration of any issues relating to the heritage setting around the listed buildings of Manor Farmhouse, Nightingale Farmhouse and Red House, including a plan detailing any sensitive areas to ensure that any development within those areas is designed in a manner which minimises any effects, where this is necessary.

1.4 The significance criteria for the assessment are as employed in Tables 10.1; 10.2 and 10.3 in Chapter 10 of the Environmental Statement.

1.5 The following section will provide the assessment of the Church of St Mary Magdalene and a discussion of the areas of sensitive heritage settings. The heritage assets referred to can be seen in Figure 1.

2.0 Assessment of Church of St Mary Magdalene

Brief Assessment of Setting, Views and Experience of the Church

2.1 This church comprises a grade I listed Medieval parish church with a prominent tower. While the church was restored in the late 19th century and has a 15th century tower, it does have some 12th and 13th century elements, which are key to its high designation.

2.2 The setting of the church comprises an immediate, intermediate and wider settings. The immediate setting comprises the church yard of the church, where architectural details can be best appreciated, along with the graveyard and memorials.

2.3 The intermediate setting comprises the area adjoining the churchyard, as far as Old Vicarage Lane to the west, and along Church Lane to the south, from where good views of the tower and its immediate setting are afforded (see Plate 1, taken from Old Vicarage Lane).

2.4 The wider setting comprises views from further afield, such as from the playing field to the west of Old Vicarage Lane and a small rural field, located immediately to the west of that (see plates 2 and 3, both taken from the south-western corner of the rural field, plate 3 is zoomed in). Glimpsed views can also be afforded from the footpaths to the north of the church, however there is considerable screening along the northern boundary of the church yard (see Plate 5, taken from the church yard looking north at the front of the church). Occasional distant views of the tower are also afforded from the wider area, for instance in footpaths to the north and also in the vicinity of Rowborough Farm.

2.5 The three aspects of the setting of the church contribute in similar ways, mostly by allowing appreciation of the architectural merit of the church, as well as its historic role at the centre of the community. The associations are better appreciated in the immediate setting, in particular with the churchyard which has a number of tombs. In the intermediate and wider settings the contribution is less strong, although the prominence of the church and its role can still be appreciated. In practice the experience of these settings is through the use of the footpaths which cross the rural field in the wider setting and allow one to pass through the different settings as one approaches the church from the southwest.

2.6 While not central to the significance of the church in the way that the historic fabric or architectural merit are, these views and settings need to be considered in allowing the church's historic role and significance to be understood and appreciated.

Impact Assessment

2.7 The proposed development of the study site would not physically intrude into the settings described above, as the recreational space in South Marston is outside of the study site, and the rural field to the west of the recreation ground is to be retained as open space, preserving long views of the church tower. The immediate setting of the church would also be unaffected, as there is considerable screening provided by the intervening landscape (see plate 4, taken from the churchyard), and also the proposed development comprises mainly domestic scale buildings, and would not include substantive structures such that would affect these views or experience. Views of the church tower from the wider area would be largely unaffected due to the retention of considerable green space within the proposed development, for example the rural field to the west of the recreation ground is to be retained as open green space, preserving the identified views from there. Also, long views from the area to the west of Rowborough Farm would also be preserved by open space. While some occasional long views of the church tower may be lost, it is clear that the vast majority would be preserved, and it is considered that in this context the loss of very few occasional long views would not materially alter the wider setting of the church, or the contribution this makes to the church's significance.

2.8 As the proposed development would not affect any of the key views identified, nor impede the experience of the church's wider setting, it is evident that the proposed development would not harm the significance of the church.

3.0 Areas of Sensitive Heritage Setting

3.1 During discussions with the SBC Conservation Officer and the Planning Officer, concern was raised that, without careful design (at reserved matters stage) and implementation at operation, the proposed development could result in unnecessary harm to some buildings as a result of unsympathetic changes to their setting. However it was also accepted that with good design no unacceptable harm would arise. To ensure that best practice and design are achieved, it was agreed that the following buildings would require consideration with regard to the design of development in the vicinity at the reserved matters stage:

- Nightingale Farm
- Red House

3.2 During the reserved matters application stage, detailed design of the proposed development will be developed with the setting and character of these buildings in mind, as necessary. Having regard to the characteristics and settings of these buildings and as all reserved matters applications would be subject to additional consultation, it is considered that no further measures beyond this are required in relation to these buildings, as this process will ensure that these matters are considered.

3.3 Of those buildings we are asked to consider by the Borough Council it is recognised that the immediate setting of Manor Farm is a contributor to its significance, and so the design of the proposed development closest to this will need to be carefully considered. Therefore an area of Sensitive Heritage Setting has been delineated around this building. The purpose of delineating this areas is to ensure that the detailed design of the proposed development within it is more carefully considered at reserved matters stage and to guarantee that the final detailed design of the proposed development minimises harm and remains sympathetic. The area is shown on Figure 1, and it is proposed that a suitably worded condition is attached to outline planning consent to require the necessary detailed design and discussions to be had, and acceptable design to be achieved before the application can be determined.

4.0 Conclusion

4.1 In conclusion, this additional heritage information report has shown that:

- The significance of the church of St Mary Magdalene would not be harmed by the proposed development.
- The setting and significance of the historic buildings noted by the SBC Conservation Officer and Planning Officer can be adequately protected by means of good design, the implementation of which could be secured via a suitably worded condition to outline planning consent.

4.2 Therefore, it is concluded that the proposed development would not result in any unacceptable harm to the historic buildings identified.

Sources

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Plate 1 Looking east towards St Mary Magdalene Church Tower

Plate 2 Looking east towards St Mary Magdalene Church Tower from rural field to the east of South Marston recreation grounds

Plate 3 Close up of view east towards St Mary Magdalene Church Tower from rural field to the east of South Marston recreation grounds

Plate 4 Looking southwest towards study site from churchyard

Plate 5 Looking north from churchyard

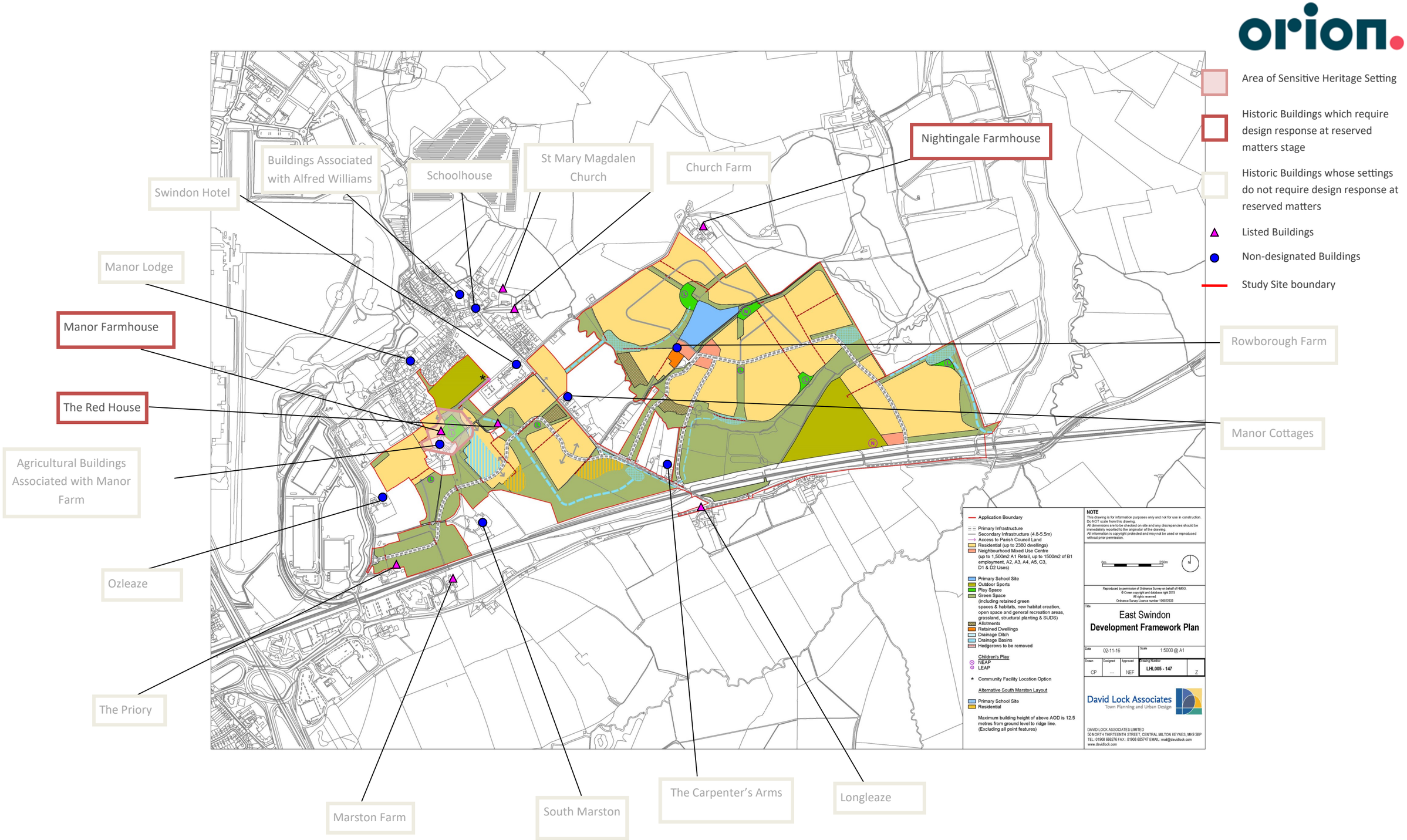

Figure 1: Study site, surrounding built heritage assets and Areas of Sensitive Heritage Settings

Data and Mapping Source: David Lock Associates

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Illustrator	W Bedford
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